

NERAI Maritime Weekly

The week's most consequential events, selected by strategic consequence and grounded in a 91-article 7-day corpus plus live NERAI data.

THE WEEK IN BRIEF - The Gulf crisis deepened across multiple fronts this week: Hormuz physical oil flow collapsed to 0.7 mb/d (-96.4% vs baseline, SEVERE), the Saudi East-West Pipeline was struck and shut down — eliminating the primary Hormuz bypass — while Houthi forces seized Perim Island and the port of Mocha, tightening their grip on Bab el-Mandeb. Against this, the NERAI 4-week disruption probability for Hormuz fell 6.8 points to 44%, a divergence from the physical collapse that is itself the key analytic signal of the week. Diplomatic back-channels flickered: an Oman-mediated Hormuz routing agreement was reported but an Iranian official cautioned no signed deal was yet expected from Monday's meeting.

01 Saudi East-West Pipeline struck and shut, last Hormuz bypass eliminated

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-12

WHY IT RANKS - The pipeline was the only credible overland bypass of the Strait of Hormuz for Saudi crude; its shutdown forecloses the primary alternative routing and concentrates the entire Gulf export risk on a single chokepoint already at SEVERE status.

A large fire broke out along the Saudi East-West Pipeline on 12 September following alleged Houthi strikes, forcing a shutdown of the line. The pipeline had been the principal overland route allowing Saudi crude to reach Yanbu on the Red Sea and bypass the Strait of Hormuz. With the pipeline offline, Saudi Arabia's ability to route oil around Hormuz is now severely constrained. Multiple outlets reported on 13 September that the shutdown raises fresh threats of an oil price surge, with oil prices already reported above \$108 per barrel earlier in the week.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The simultaneous closure of Hormuz (physical oil flow at 0.7 mb/d, -96.4% vs baseline as of 14 September) and the shutdown of the East-West Pipeline removes what energy analysts and markets had treated as a structural redundancy in Gulf export architecture. A Middle East Monitor analysis this week argued that markets were misreading Gulf supply risk precisely by assuming bypass capacity remained available — the pipeline strike validates that warning. Saudi Arabia's Yanbu export terminal, the pipeline's Red Sea terminus, is now unreachable via the overland route, and Bab el-Mandeb itself is under simultaneous Houthi pressure (oil flow 5.1 mb/d, -41.7% vs baseline), meaning neither the Hormuz nor the Red Sea corridor is functioning normally. The compound effect could trigger P&I; and sanctions-cover reviews and upward pressure on war-risk pricing for any vessel attempting Gulf loading. Geopolitically, the strike — attributed to Houthis — extends Iran's proxy network's operational reach from maritime interdiction to strategic energy infrastructure, a qualitative escalation. Gulf producer states with no alternative routing will face mounting pressure to draw down storage or negotiate emergency passage arrangements.

NERAI SIGNAL - Strait of Hormuz chokepoint oil flow: 0.7 mb/d, -96.4% vs baseline (SEVERE) [observed 2026-09-14, NERAI]; Cape of Good Hope oil flow deteriorated 22.2 points to -12.7% vs baseline [NERAI, change since 2026-09-07], consistent with rerouting flows thinning as the bypass option via the Red Sea also degrades.

Sources: sott.net: <https://www.sott.net/article/508351-Huge-fire-breaks-out-along-Saudi-Hormuz-bypass-East-West-Oil-Pipeline-after-alleged-Houthi-Strikes> | tradearabia.com: <https://tradedearabia.com:443/News/486090/Saudi-pipeline-shutdown-raises-fresh-threat-of-oil-price-surge> | middleeastmonitor.com: <https://www.middleeastmonitor.com/20260912-the-illusion-of-redundancy-why-oil-markets-are-misreading-gulf-supply-risk/>

02 Hormuz forward risk falls 6.8 pts to 44% even as physical flow hits -96.4% — a critical divergence

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-13

WHY IT RANKS - The NERAI model and the physical data are moving in opposite directions at Hormuz: the forward disruption probability is easing while observed oil flow has collapsed to near-zero — a divergence that is itself the most decision-relevant analytic finding of the week for charterers, insurers and policymakers.

NERAI's 4-week disruption probability for the Strait of Hormuz fell 6.8 points over the past seven days to 44%, and the 8-week probability fell 4.9 points to 72%. At the same time, physical oil flow through Hormuz stood at just 0.7 mb/d as of 14 September, down -96.4% versus baseline — a SEVERE classification. Tankers were reported by Hellenic Shipping News and Asharq Al-Awsat to be transiting Hormuz with AIS transponders off ('in the dark'), making tracking-firm volume estimates unreliable. CENTCOM stated it redirected 99 commercial ships as Iran's maritime blockade continued, and Hormuz shipping traffic was separately reported to have fallen to single digits.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The divergence between the forward model easing and the physical collapse deepening is the single most important signal in this edition: the model's probability decline likely reflects the opening of back-channel diplomacy — an Oman-mediated meeting was reported for Monday 15 September, with Iran and Oman reported to have agreed on new entry and exit routes for Hormuz, though an Iranian official cautioned that no signed deal was yet expected. If the diplomatic track advances, the forward model is leading the physical recovery correctly; if talks stall, the model will snap back upward sharply. The AIS-dark transits mean that the 0.7 mb/d figure likely understates actual flow — tracking firms' volume estimates diverge sharply in exactly this situation — but even with that caveat, Hormuz remains far below any functional threshold. Bandar Abbas port calls fell a further 70.5 points to -39.7% versus the 90-day average (SEVERE DROP), corroborating the physical shutdown rather than the diplomatic optimism. For compliance officers, vessels transiting without AIS in a war-risk zone face heightened screening exposure; for

insurers, the gap between model and reality is a basis risk that cannot be hedged until the two converge.

NERAI SIGNAL - Strait of Hormuz 4-week disruption probability fell from 51% to 44% (-6.8 pts) since 2026-09-07, while physical oil flow stands at 0.7 mb/d (-96.4% vs baseline, SEVERE) and Bandar Abbas port calls fell 70.5 points to -39.7% vs 90-day average [all NERAI, observed 2026-09-13/14] — model and physical data diverging.

Sources: hellenicshippingnews.com: <https://www.hellenicshippingnews.com/appec-tankers-transit-hormuz-in-the-dark-as-oil-flows-persist/> | khaama.com: <https://www.khaama.com/centcom-says-us-redirected-99-commercial-ships-as-iran-maritime-blockade-continues/> | arynews.tv: <https://arynews.tv/news/liveblog/iran-war-2026-live-updates-trump-us-israel?update=13-Sep-2026-09-55-00>

03 Houthis seize Mocha port and Perim Island, placing Bab el-Mandeb under direct control

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-10

WHY IT RANKS - Houthi seizure of both Mocha port and Perim Island gives the group physical dominance over the southern entry to Bab el-Mandeb, the chokepoint carrying 5.1 mb/d of oil (-41.7% vs baseline) and representing the only viable bypass route for traffic avoiding Hormuz.

Houthi forces seized the port of Mocha on Yemen's Red Sea coast, reported by CNN on 10 September, and separately seized Perim Island, which sits at the southern narrows of Bab el-Mandeb, according to multiple outlets including Investment Watch Blog and Big News Network. Iran was reported by Gulf News on 11 September to have deployed hundreds of IRGC officers to Yemen to support targeting of Bab el-Mandeb and global shipping. Houthi strikes on the Saudi border were continuing as of 13 September, with multiple sources reporting a tightening grip on the oil route.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - Perim Island commands the western channel of Bab el-Mandeb; its seizure means that Houthi forces now hold physical terrain at both the northern (Mocha) and the southern narrows of the strait, not merely the ability to fire from inland positions. Bab el-Mandeb oil flow is already at 5.1 mb/d (-41.7% vs baseline, SEVERE as of 14 September), and the NERAI 4-week disruption probability for Red Sea/Bab el-Mandeb stands at 43%. The strategic logic of Iran's proxy positioning is now visible as a two-chokepoint squeeze: Hormuz is physically shut and its Saudi overland bypass has been struck; Bab el-Mandeb, the route that would allow Red Sea-bound tankers from any alternative loading point to reach Europe or Asia, is now under terrain control of an Iran-aligned force. Gulf News's claim of IRGC deployment to Yemen is an allegation by that outlet and should be treated as contested pending independent corroboration. The Cape of Good Hope remains the only open rerouting option for westbound cargoes, but oil flow there deteriorated 22.2 points this week to -12.7% versus baseline, suggesting rerouting demand is already straining that corridor. War-risk premium for any vessel transiting either chokepoint could rise further, and P&I; cover for voyages touching Yemeni-controlled waters warrants urgent review.

NERAI SIGNAL - Bab el-Mandeb oil flow: 5.1 mb/d, -41.7% vs baseline (SEVERE) [observed 2026-09-14, NERAI]; Red Sea/Bab el-Mandeb 4-week disruption probability: 43% (-3.8 pts since 2026-09-07) [NERAI, observed 2026-09-13].

Sources: edition.cnn.com: <https://edition.cnn.com/2026/09/10/middleeast/houthis-capture-mocha-red-sea-strait-intl> | gulfnews.com: <https://gulfnews.com/world/mena/iran-deploys-hundreds-of-irgc-officers-to-yemen-to-target-bab-al-mandab-strait-1.500670468>

04 Iranian commercial vessel struck near Qeshm/Hormuz, 1 killed — fresh attack in active conflict zone

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-13

WHY IT RANKS - A fresh vessel strike on 13 September, with one fatality confirmed by Iranian authorities, demonstrates that ship-to-ship and shore-to-ship attacks remain active at the highest observed frequency, maintaining acute compliance and crew-safety risk for any operator with Gulf exposure.

Iranian media reported on 13 September that an Iranian commercial vessel was struck near Qeshm Island in the Strait of Hormuz, killing one person and injuring three. Iran attributed the strike to a US attack, a claim that the corpus does not independently corroborate, and which should be treated as an Iranian government allegation. The strike followed a reported Iranian attack on a US spy drone in the Strait of Hormuz on 12 September. Three ships carrying 44 Indian seafarers were separately caught in Gulf attacks this week, with all reported safe as of 12 September.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The 13 September strike on the Iranian commercial vessel near Qeshm is the latest in what Asharq Al-Awsat described earlier this week as the biggest wave of attacks on shipping since the war began, and it signals that neither side has moved toward de-escalation in practice despite diplomatic contacts in Oman. Iran's allegation that the US struck a commercial vessel — if it gains traction internationally — could complicate US efforts to maintain allied support for the maritime redirection operation covering 99 commercial ships. The involvement of seafarers from multiple nationalities (Indian, Filipino in prior incidents) is internationalising crew-safety pressure in ways that could constrain flag-state tolerance for Gulf voyages. Supertanker rates reported at \$800,000 per day reflect the market's pricing of this risk, and vintage tonnage is reportedly capturing a freight premium as operators struggle to source available hulls. The shadow-fleet pressure index rose 4.4 points to 48.3 (Moderate) this week — consistent with increased demand for vessels outside conventional insurance and flag structures, which in turn elevates sanctions-evasion screening burdens for port-state control authorities in receiving ports.

NERAI SIGNAL - Shadow-fleet pressure index rose +4.4 to 48.3 (Moderate) [NERAI, change since 2026-09-07], consistent with heightened demand for non-conventional tonnage as war-risk pricing escalates in the Gulf.

Sources: rte.ie: <https://www.rte.ie/news/2026/0913/1591336-iran-war/> | thefrontierpost.com: <https://thefrontierpost.com/iran-says-us-attack-on-commercial-vessel-in-gulf-kills-1-injures-3/> | oneindia.com:

<https://www.oneindia.com/international/3-ships-44-indian-seafarers-caught-in-gulf-attacks-all-reported-safe-8203101.html>

05 Eastern Mediterranean 8-week risk hits 82% — highest forward probability in NERAI corpus

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-13

WHY IT RANKS - The Eastern Mediterranean's 8-week disruption probability has risen to 82% — the highest forward reading in the NERAI corpus — driven by the chain of events connecting Hormuz, Bab el-Mandeb and the Levant, and it is accelerating (+0.5 pts on 8-week since 7 September) even as other corridors ease, making it the most exposed forward watch item.

The underlying escalation thread — US-Iran tanker war, Houthi advances, Israeli strikes in Lebanon reported on 7 September — is now being priced into Eastern Mediterranean forward risk at a rate that diverges from all other corridors. As of 13 September, the NERAI 4-week disruption probability for the Eastern Mediterranean stands at 59% (+6.8 pts since 7 September) and the 8-week stands at 82% (+0.5 pts), making it the most exposed corridor at both horizons. The 2-week probability rose 5.6 points to 25%, the largest 2-week gain of any corridor this week. Suez Canal forward risk is also deteriorating on both the model (4-week: 39%, -1.4 pts) and physical flow (-11.6 pts on flow), creating a compound watch condition on the corridor linking the Eastern Mediterranean to the Red Sea.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The Eastern Mediterranean's forward probability surge is structurally distinct from the Hormuz event: it is not driven by a single chokepoint closure but by the confluence of the Levant conflict (Israeli strikes in Lebanon), Houthi overland strikes toward the Saudi-Red Sea axis, and the knock-on threat to Suez Canal traffic volumes. The Suez Canal is the one corridor simultaneously deteriorating on both the forward model and physical flow — a compound risk that NERAI flags as the key watch item, since single-corridor stress is absorbable but a second corridor joining it is not. For operators with Mediterranean port calls, insurance renewal negotiations for war-risk zones in the Eastern Med will increasingly reference the 8-week probability curve. The YaLibnan analysis published 12 September explicitly frames the threat as Iran's proxies building a chain of chokepoints from Hormuz to Suez — whether or not that strategic ambition is fully coordinated, the operational effect is that vessels have no conflict-free trunk route between the Indian Ocean and Europe. Sovereign bond spreads for Eastern Mediterranean importers dependent on energy throughput are a secondary watch item outside the NERAI model scope but implied by these forward readings.

NERAI SIGNAL - Eastern Mediterranean 4-week disruption probability: 59% (+6.8 pts since 2026-09-07); 8-week: 82% (+0.5 pts) — highest forward probability in the NERAI corpus [observed 2026-09-13]. Suez Canal compound deterioration: 4-week forward risk -1.4 pts and physical flow -11.6 pts simultaneously [NERAI, change since 2026-09-07].

Sources: yalibnan.com: <https://yalibnan.com/2026/09/12/how-to-stop-irans-proxies-from-building-a-chain-of-chokepoints-from-hormuz-to-suez/> | dw.com: <https://www.dw.com/en/middle-east-israeli-strikes-kill-a-dozen-in-lebanon/live-79133242> | opednews.com: https://www.opednews.com/populum/page.php?f=The-Oil-Chokepoint-Is-Movi-Crisis_Energy_Oil-Cost-Of-_Oil-Crisis-Global-Disruption-260912-970.html

Grounded generation: events are selected only from the week's retrieved article corpus and NERAI feeds; every event carries its sources; each event states the date the issuing authority acted, which is distinct from the date any article about it was published; quantitative figures carry their observation period; maximum five events, fewer when the week is thin. NERAI-UNRESTRICTED.